The Cold Between Stars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31620179.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Destiny (Video Games)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Oryx (Destiny)

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by DeltaFell

Summary

Catra grabbed the sword, and everything changed. Now what?

The sword in Catra’s hand was quickly wreathed in pale green flames. Catra began to scream, but realized her hand was not on fire. At the same time, Entrapta’s machine began to glow a bluish-purple. As the green fire, soulfire, she knew it was called, engulfed the point of the sword, the portal machine’s glow turned the same color as soulfire and flames licked at the edge of its glow.

Why did she know it was called soulfire? How did she know that? Something was wrong.

Through the soulfire portal stepped a mountain of a man. He was covered in muddy brown and red chitin, with three green eyes and a hammer-like head. Flaring out behind him were massive wings, albeit tattered ones.

He held in his right hand a massive sword resembling an older, more worn, version of Catra's sword. He swung it before him, grasping it's hilt in both clawed hands, slamming it into the ground. He locked gazes with everyone in the room.

As her gaze met his, Catra shuddered. She felt a malevolence in his stare, a hatred older than anything she ever knew. As she stared back, Catra understood things. She understood he was Oryx, ruler of an intergalactic army. She understood he wasn't really here- not yet. He had found them, and nothing could stop him now. Catra couldn't explain, not even to herself, how she understood these truths, only that she did.

Green soulfire spread from Oryx's illusion and washed over the room

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Catra blinks and looks around. Where is she? Who is she? It takes some time before she remembers fully.

She is Catra, Champion of Oryx. She is in Salineas, razing the city as she prepares Etheria to become a part of the final shape, when Oryx arrives.

Something was wrong. Something terrible, well and truly awful was wrong with the world.

Nothing was wrong. Oryx would fix it all when he arrived. Finally, she could be perfect. Everything would be perfect in the final shape.

Catra's attention is drawn outwards by a voice. A man is calling to her, the man who led the Horde. She couldn't recall his name. Why didn't she know his name?

At his beckoning, Catra raises her sword, that great and terrible gift, and charges into battle.

Hordak. That was his name. Catra is scared now, scared of the power of the sword, scared of what it's doing to her. At first minutes, then hours, then days, and now weeks are disappearing. It's more than that however. Catra has noticed that her sword is feeding and amplifying her darkest parts. She is angrier now, empty of the hope that she could win, that she could ever get Adora, her Adora, back. She's been cruel to her soldiers, demanding perfection from everyone.

If they cannot withstand her demands, then they are weak and deserved to fall.

Something is wrong with her, Catra is certain of it. She doesn't understand it, but she suspects the sword is to blame. Scorpia could help her. Scorpia would know what to do. Where is she now?

The Rebellion had to be up to something. Catra's spy had gone silent, and so had the Rebellion. They hadn't made any maneuvers or attacks in weeks. Double Trouble's last messages mentioned a superweapon of some kind, called the Heart of Etheria.

The voice had returned last night, when she had first realized that the Rebellion must be working on activating their superweapon. It mostly asked her bizarre questions from time to time. She never

really understood why, exactly, but answering it's questions always felt both inherently wrong and something she must do.

What purpose drives you? What pain drives your anger?

"She left me, okay? I wasn't enough for her. I'm never enough" Catra said.

You do as your past commands. You scratch and claw your way to fit into this world. You feed upon the weaknesses of the Rebellion to grow your power. But you are never safe. You can never stop.

"I … that's not true. I'm safe! I have power! Are you going to say anything but meaningless garbage?"

Your sword has power you do not. Take it in your hand and cut a wound through space. Inflict your will upon the world.

"Great, more cryptic shit from you. I'll figure you out later. Right now, I have some princesses to sort out. For good this time."

Hordak found out. Why did that voice have to be right? She was never safe. Hordak found out about Entrapta going to Beast Island, and then he tried to kill her. His fondness for that princess was his weakness. She asserted her existence over his by right of violence.

From behind her came a voice, “Hey Catra.”

The familiar voice sent a shiver down her spine. Catra turned around, and saw Adora standing behind her, one hand on her hip, the Sword of Protection in bracelet form around her wrist

“No. You can’t do this. You can’t come in and take this from me now. I’m strong, stronger than you will ever be. I killed Hordak, and by killing him I have taken his power for my own.”

Adora’s face wrinkled in confusion, “Kitten I knew this would get a rise out of you, but I never expected you to be so unhinged. It’s depressing, really, to see you sink so low.”

Adora’s body shifted, revealing they really were Double Trouble.

“You know, I think I’ve finally figured out your character. You’ve been hurt, kitten. People hurt you, left you behind, left you vulnerable.”

Catra spluttered.

“But it wasn’t their fault,” Double Trouble’s form shifted to Scorpia’s, “It’s you wildcat. You drive them away.”

Catra lashed out in rage. What did Double Trouble know of her problems? They hadn’t been here, they hadn’t lived her life. She

was tired, and she was slow after having fought Hordak. Double Trouble was able to avoid her with ease. Why did they have to be so irritating even in combat?

"Why are you doing this?"

"It's simple really. They have bigger guns now than you ever could. I just did what I had to to stay out of their sights."

They pulled out a datapad to show Catra.

"Your forces have been destroyed Catra, you can't win now. It's best to just give in." As they spoke, the datapad shifted to show her forces near Salineas routed, then the Whispering Woods, where princess magic pushed back against her bots.

This can't be happening. It has to be a trick, a ploy of some kind. She couldn't be losing here, now. Not at the zenith of her power.

"Well, I really should be going. I certainly don't want to be here when Glimmer activates that weapon. Toodleloo Kitten."

Catra could feel her victory slipping away as she slid to her knees. Was this really it? Was she fated to be nothing but a footnote, a failure of a commander?

Glimmer teleports into the wrecked throne room, staff at the ready. Catra doesn't look up. She doesn't have the energy or the drive to anymore.

"Not so tough now, are you?" Glimmer asked.

"Do it," Catra said weakly. Her fight with Hordak was taking its toll, "I'm done for."

Despite the fatigue, Catra felt clearer than she had in ages, since Adora left. The background whispers, like fingertips on the surface of her mind, had finally retreated.

Before Glimmer can respond, she unleashes a blood-curdling scream. Catra's head snaps up at the sudden, unexpected noise. Glimmer doubles over, and the writing of the first ones etches itself across Glimmer's body. Magic surges up from her, into the sky.

"Adora was right, Light Hope used me. She's activated the Heart."

" So? I thought you wanted to win. Use your weapon." Catra didn't have the energy to fight anymore, but this was odd.

"I can't. It would destroy everything. I have to try and stop it." Glimmer stood and left the throne room.

She might as well follow, Catra thought, and get to see what happens before it kills her. Catra stood up, wincing as her injuries protested the movement.

They were aboard the Dreadnought. Oryx's flagship and biggest weapon. The whispers returned as soon as she was teleported aboard. She thought the familiar noise would be comforting, but now they were an angry intrusion. Glimmer and her were pulled aboard the Dreadnought as soon as it appeared in the newly star-filled sky, and greeted by Oryx himself.

She wasn't entirely certain she wanted to know why she blurted out about the Heart of Etheria, or why she mentioned Glimmer being a necessary part. She justified it as self-preservation, but even that sounded hollow to her ears.

Well, at least she had Glimmer to talk to on this First-Ones-forsaken ship. Better than any of Oryx's Hive. Their bright green three eyes always seemed to be deciding which part of her would be better to eat first.

Oryx had decided to put on a show of force today, apparently. One of his Knights had been so troublesome, Oryx was handling matters personally.

The Knight stood defiant before Oryx, only slightly bowing his head when brought to kneel before him. In his alien language, he said something defiant, rising from the enforced kneel. Whatever it was, Oryx must not have liked that response.

Oryx had extended his hand, and a black, star-spangled energy consumed the Knight entirely. After a few seconds, the Knight returned, but he was different. He was coated in a goop resembling the energy that consumed him. Every few seconds the knight would twitch violently, his whole body shuddering. The Knight was returned physically, but he was not the same. His strong defiance had melted into molded obedience.

She had trouble falling asleep that night. The scene replayed in her head over and over, but rather than the Knight, it was Adora brought to kneel before Oryx. She had to keep Adora from coming before him.

"Glimmer, get up."

Oryx had kept Glimmer in a cell, but being his 'Champion' or whatever, Catra was allowed to roam free. Catra had been uncertain of her intended actions all morning, but when she saw Glimmer's despondency in the cell, she knew this was the right course of action. Her 'one good thing,' as Glimmer might have put it.

"What is it?"

“Adora’s been spotted on her way here. She’s going to come here, for you, and, and then Oryx is going to do that thing again, and then she’ll be gone. She’ll still be here, but Adora will be gone. I can’t let that happen. I won’t.”

“Why are you doing this? You’ll be killed, surely” Glimmer said.

“Yeah, I know. I guess it’s just my ‘one good thing,’ Sparkles.” Catra smiled ruefully.

Catra released Glimmer from her cell and walked throughout the Dreadnought with her, as she was wont to do. During their walk, they passed several of Oryx’s brood, but none stood in the way of his Champion. Before long, they reached the room Catra had claimed as her own.

“I can open a portal to Adora, I’m fairly certain, but I can’t hold it open for very long.”

The voice had instructed her in what it called ‘tearing a wound upon the world.’ She’d never tried it before, but she could only think of a portal. If she was wrong, Oryx would very likely have her head, but she was rarely wrong about these sorts of things since she had picked up the sword.

Catra heard Glimmer rummaging in her stuff, but before she could comment, one of Oryx's Knights entered her room. He was covered in the strange star-spangled energy, the Taken, such individuals were called by Oryx. She wasn't sure how, but Catra knew this was the same Knight as the one she saw that night. The recognition chilled her.

"Fuck, it's time to go Sparkles!" Catra reached over to where she had laid her sword, an out of place corner so it's chitinous form, once fascinating, now disturbing, would not trouble her sleep.

Catra took the sword in her hand, and focused her will. She thought of Adora, and what Oryx would do to her if she boarded his ship looking for Glimmer. She thought of her own power, proved by her violence upon Etheria. Catra focused her power, recognized by proof of combat, and bound it to her thoughts of Adora. Once she was confident of the strength of the bond, Catra raised her sword and swung down.

Following the path of the blade, a tear opened in the space of her room. The edge was rimmed with green soulfire, but the center was clear. And visible through the portal was Adora, sitting at the helm of the First Ones ship.

The Knight noticed the hole, and emanated a howling shriek, long and undulating. He raised his blade and charged Catra.

"Glimmer, go through! I'll follow you after I've dealt with him!" Catra shouted as she raised her blade in response to the Knight's challenge.

“Adora, if I don’t make it, don’t come for me. Oryx has power, strange power, greater than anything we’ve ever seen.”

Her blade clashed with his, and her focus wavered for a second.

“Catra, I can’t just leave you there with him!” Adora said

“Yes you can, and you should. All my life I’ve done evil things for an evil cause,” Catra cut herself off to dodge the Knight’s swing.

“I’d like to do one good thing with my life, Adora. Now go! I can feel the portal collapsing. Return to Etheria, and hope you can fight him off.”

“No, Catra, I left you once before, I’m not leaving you again.”

In the rapidly shrinking portal, Catra could see Adora hesitate.

“Catra, I ...” Adora’s words were cut off as the portal shut with a final ring.

Catra had been brought before Oryx. She knelt before his mammoth figure, feeling incredibly small.

"If you will not serve willingly, then perhaps you would serve better unwillingly. All things may work towards the final shape, but not all things have a place in the final shape. Do you?"

Oryx's voice was low and gravelly, but somehow contained millenia of screams within every syllable. Catra scowled at him, and spat.

"Fuck you. You'll never win now, not with Adora gone. You can't compete with the Heart of Etheria."

"Perhaps. But will they be able to withstand you?"

A dark energy gathered in his hands, and became speckled with stars. Catra felt paralyzed at the realization of what was about to happen to her.

What purpose drives you? What pain drives your anger?

"No! I won't be one of your soldiers! I refuse to fight and kill in your name."

You do as your past commands. You scratch and claw your way to fit into this world. You feed upon the weaknesses of the Rebellion to grow your power. But you are never safe. You can never stop.

Catra struggled fruitlessly against the strange Taken holding her in place as the voice continued.

You deserve safety. You deserve your own power.

There is a knife for you. It is shaped like [I have the power].

Take up the knife. Welcome it within you. Take your new shape.

The glowing orb in Oryx's hand flashed brighter, and the last thing Catra felt was the cold between stars.

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